

MGT 409: LEADING IN NETWORKS AND ORGANIZATIONS

WINTER QUARTER 2025

THURSDAYS 2:00-4:50pm (OTRSN 4E106)

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Office hours: By appointment (see Canvas page for link to my Calendly)

Teaching Assistant

TBD

DESCRIPTION

Why do some organizations succeed but others fail? And what can be done about it? The answers to these questions are consequential to your professional success because, regardless of career choice, people spend most of their lives as part of one organization or another. Building on lessons from prior leadership and team management courses, MGT 409 explores major determinants of a firm's success or failure, and how to manage challenging organizational dynamics. Topics include social and professional networks, organizational networks and information exchange in markets, equity and inclusion, organizational culture and innovation, organizational design, corruption, organizational scandals, and fostering change in firms.

Instructional methods. To translate theory into practice, this course is taught in an applied manner. Class sessions are structured around group exercises that allow you to engage with and experience relevant course concepts firsthand. Exercises are followed by instructor-facilitated group discussions of illustrative case studies and evidence-based insights generated by behavioral and management scientists, which contextualize your experiences and ground course concepts in real organizational settings.

OBJECTIVES

The central learning objective is to provide you with an organizational strategy toolkit, which can be used throughout your career. By the end of this course, you will be able to:

- Identify important characteristics of your social and professional network and understand how to leverage your network to benefit your career and your firm
- Identify the major contributing factors to an organization's success or failure, and critically analyze/diagnose these processes in real organizations
- Develop evidence-based solutions to challenging organizational dynamics and effectively communicate your insights and strategies

REQUIRED MATERIALS

All course materials are available on Canvas. Please note that slide decks uploaded to Canvas after each class will not include all details of exercises and cases due to copyrights.

Technology Policy. Please bring a computer or tablet to class. Many in-class exercises require running a software program or accessing an online platform. Please reach out as soon as possible if you anticipate having an issue consistently accessing a laptop or tablet, and we will find a work-around. All class sessions are video recorded, and recordings are uploaded to Canvas (see Panopto tab). Due to copyrights for the cases and exercises used in this class, other videotaping and audio recording is prohibited unless approved by Rady administrators.

Class Policy for use of Generative AI: This policy applies to use of various new generative AI tools that can generate text, images, etc., in response to prompts by users (e.g., ChatGPT, BingChat, Bard, Midjourney, etc.). These new tools and programs have considerable potential to streamline and augment our work. You are permitted to use these tools for this class, with several caveats and conditions:

1. These tools should augment your work, not replace it. For instance, large language models can provide help improving the quality of your writing, identify new sources, get high-level summaries of complex ideas or terms, or pressure test your arguments for logical inconsistencies. These tools can help you get started on idea, help overcome writer's block, or refine YOUR original ideas. These tools should not be used generate content that you simply put your name on. This constitutes an academic integrity violation, much like taking another individual's work and misrepresenting it as your own original work (see end of syllabus for details on UCSD's academic integrity policy). Moreover, such an approach is likely to lead to low quality responses and low scores because these tools often produce rudimentary and superficial analysis.
2. If you use generative AI for an assignment, be transparent about if/how it was used in a footnote or citation. Using generative AI tools without attributing credit will be treated as comparable to failing to properly credit and cite/reference other people's contributions and sources used in your work.
3. Large language models have documented issues with hallucination and inaccuracy (e.g., generating fake citations, failing logical arguments, misrepresenting sources, etc.). You are fully responsible for the content you submit in your assignments and will be graded accordingly.

SCHEDULE AND COURSE FORMAT

A schedule with details on topics, exercises, cases, and assignments is available on Canvas and at the end of this syllabus. Due to the exercise- and group discussion-based format of this class, in-person attendance is critical to your and your classmates' learning experience. This class cannot employ a hybrid format because it is too logistically challenging for students to complete in-class exercises with a combination of group members attending in person and remotely. If there is a compelling reason you cannot attend class in person on a regular basis, please reach out as soon as possible so we can develop alternative accommodations.

ASSIGNMENTS

Your course grade includes individual assignments, class participation, an open-book quiz, and a final group project. An overview of each assignment is included in the table below and more details are provided on the following pages and Canvas.

Assignments	Scoring
Class Engagement Holistic assessment of engagement in class, including attendance, engagement in group exercises, participation in class-wide discussions, and peer evaluations. Scored individually.	25 pts (~16% of grade)
Thought Questions Responses to 4 short-answer questions. Scored individually (10 pts/each).	40 pts (~25% of grade)
Exit Polls 1-2 sentence reflections always due within 1 day of end of class session. Scored individually (1pt/each).	8 pts (~6% of grade)
Open-book Final Quiz Short-answer style quiz. Scored individually.	20 pts (~13% of grade)
Group Project: Real World Case Analysis Postmortem analysis of a real organizational challenge or failure event & a proposed do-over strategy. Deliverables include a written memo and brief in-class presentation. Group grades.	60 pts (~38% of grade)
Group Project: Milestones Mini assignments to facilitate groups' progress toward a completed final project: • Select final project topic (1 pt, group grade) • Outline key ideas and analytic approach to receive feedback (1 pt, group grade) • Complete peer evaluations (1 pt, individual grade)	3 pts (~2% of grade)
Total	156 pts

Class Engagement (individual grade, 25 pts). Everyone's learning experience benefits from high-quality discussions and active engagement in class exercises, so we should all contribute by participating in class. Your participation score is a holistic assessment that takes several things into account:

- **Attendance:** Due to the number of in-class group exercises and discussions, this course cannot accommodate a hybrid format (see course format section for more information). Attending class in person is important for your and your classmates' learning experience. ***But do not come to class if you are sick!*** You will never be penalized for missing class due to illness or other extenuating circumstances beyond your control. If you will be missing a class, please reach out to me as soon as possible so we can work out an alternative plan for you to earn participation credit.
- **In-class participation:** This includes preparing for, actively participating in, and thoughtfully contributing to group discussions, group exercises, and class-wide discussions. The quality of your contributions is more important than the quantity of your contributions.
- **Canvas discussion board participation:** In-class participation is not the only way that you can contribute. You can also participate by posting to the discussion boards on Canvas. As an example, a good contribution would be posting a link to an article that illustrates a relevant course concept and briefly commenting.
- **Peer evaluations:** You will be asked to complete a survey at the end of the quarter that asks you about how you see each other as contributors and participants in class, which I will use to augment my personal assessment. You will also receive credit for completing these evaluations (see final project milestones).

Thought Questions (individual grade). There are 4 Thought Question responses due throughout the quarter (10 points/each). The goal of this assignment is to reflect on your intuition, educated opinions, and beliefs about handling organizational challenges, managing various workplace situations, or making career decisions, and what information has led you to form these opinions. For instance, you might be asked to consider a hypothetical workplace scenario and what decisions you would make or how you would handle certain challenges. This helps you draw direct links between course concepts and your personal experiences. This assignment provides a foundation for discussing new evidence and learnings on these same topics during class, which might support or challenge your current beliefs and opinions. When writing these responses, I recommend keeping the following in mind:

- Responses should articulate a clear perspective/argument and be supported by evidence. There are no incorrect stances or positions, but you are graded on how clearly you articulate that position and the evidence you are drawing upon to justify that perspective. You can incorporate traditional and anecdotal evidence like personal experiences, learnings from this class or other courses, advice from peers or mentors, evidence from reliable sources (e.g., news articles, articles written by experts, white papers), etc.
- Responses are always due before the start of class.
- Responses should be concise and generative for in-class discussions (max of 300 words in total). Excessively long responses will not receive high scores.
- Although you are always welcome to discuss course material with your classmates, these responses must be written individually.

Exit Polls (individual grade). At the end of Classes 2-9, you will briefly reflect on what concepts from that class session you found most interesting and what is still confusing, if anything. These exit polls provide me with information about the class's progress and what concepts need to be reviewed. Reflecting at the end of a class session has also been shown to significantly improve retention of the information. Answers should be 1-2 sentences and completed within 24 hours of the end of the class session (each response is scored complete/incomplete).

Open-book Final Quiz (individual grade). During finals, you will complete an open-book, take-home online quiz. The goal of the quiz is to test your ability to analyze, apply, and draw connections between key course concepts, rather than memorization of course content. Additional details about the format of the quiz will be provided in class. Quiz responses must be completed individually. The quiz questions will be available on Canvas for download, and you will have 1 week to complete them (deadlines on Canvas). If there is a compelling reason you cannot complete the quiz during the allotted time span, please reach out ASAP so we can come up with an alternative plan.

Group Project: Real World Case Analysis (group grade, 60 pts). To demonstrate your ability to apply course concepts and communicate evidence-based solutions, you will work on a team to conduct a postmortem analysis of a real organizational challenge or failure event and propose a do-over strategy. This final project includes a written memo and an in-class presentation. Your team will be your study group, and each team can pick their topic. I recommend using the following steps as a guide for approaching this group project:

1. **Pick an organizational failure event or challenge that you find interesting.** Feel free to interpret this broadly. Think about a firm that has faced and failed to overcome a competitive challenge, failed in a major or meaningful way, or was embroiled in a scandal. History is full of organizational failures, giving you many possible topics. There is a list of possible topics on Canvas to give you inspiration, but you are not limited to this list. All topics are subject to my final approval. The constraints on topic selection are:
 - It must be an organizational failure and not a single person's failure.
 - It cannot already be covered in a case study discussed in class (see schedule at the end of the syllabus for a list of cases being used in class).
 - The topic must be well enough known that there is sufficient evidence to analyze.
 - No two groups can do the same topic. Once you identify your topic, put it on the sign-up list on Canvas to claim it.

Keep in mind that many organizational failures have had serious consequences for people's lives and livelihoods. Please be respectful of this when selecting your topic and conducting your analysis.

2. **Figure out what happened, why it happened, and what you would have done differently.** I recommend reviewing the final project grading rubric available on Canvas to understand how your project will be evaluated. A compelling postmortem analysis should address the following and be supported by reliable evidence:
 - Description/background context: What happened and why is it important for us to understand?
 - Analysis: What were the major contributing factors or catalysts to this failure event, and why?

- Proposed do-over strategy: Imagine that you have gone back in time and the firm has hired your team as consultants to help them navigate this challenge or failure event in real time. You are encouraged to approach this creatively. For instance, depending on the type of failure event, you could imagine your team was hired just before the failure occurred (i.e., you focus on preventing the failure) or after a failure becomes public (i.e., you focus on improving the firm's post-scandal response). What are your strategic recommendations for how the firm should handle this situation, or could have avoided it altogether? Why will your proposed strategy be successful?
3. **Tell us about your insights.** Write up your analysis and proposed do-over strategy in a memo and present your findings to class.

Written memo: This is a report of your evidence, analysis, insights, and do-over strategy. You can be creative with formatting, and I recommend thinking about the most compelling, informative, and persuasive structure to present this information to the firm's leadership. The memo should not be longer than 2,000 words (equivalent of ~8 pgs double spaced with 12-pt font). Appendices with supplementary evidence, tables/figures, references, brief abstracts, and title pages are excluded from the word count. Excessively long memos will not receive high scores.

In-class presentation: Your group will have 10-15 minutes during Class 10 to present your findings to your classmates (additional details provided in class). These presentations are intended to be overviews and are not expected to cover everything that is in your written memo. Think critically about what is most important.

Note: You will be learning course content relevant to your project through Class 9, which is only a few days before the final presentations. I understand this is a time crunch and do not expect Class 9 content to be integrated into the presentation (but you are welcome to if you'd like). But you are given adequate time to integrate any/all relevant course concepts for the written memo.

Group Project Milestones. To ensure that your group progresses toward a completed final project, there are several mini assignments due during the quarter:

- Select your project topic and list it on the Final Project Topic Sign-Up on Canvas (complete/incomplete, group grade).
- Submit an outline of your key ideas and analytic approach (complete/incomplete, group grade). I will provide feedback on your outline during the in-class final project workshop to help you develop your ideas.
- Complete peer evaluation survey (complete/incomplete, individual grade). Link to survey is provided on Canvas.

GRADING POLICIES

All grading rubrics are on each assignments' page on Canvas. Please review the rubrics in advance of submitting assignments to ensure you include all required information.

Grading. Letter grade conversions follow a traditional approach (e.g., 90.0-93.9% is A–, 94.0-96.9% is A, 97.0% or higher is A+, and so on). I do not round final grades because students can bolster their grade by completing the extra credit assignment. I also do not negotiate final grades. Please see follow the formal grade appeal policy if you have concerns about a grade you received.

Extra Credit (individual grade). You can complete one additional Thought Question response as extra credit. This response is scored out of 3 points, which will be added to your overall grade. The Extra Credit Thought Question response is due the same day and time as quiz responses & final project memo.

Grade Appeals. To formally appeal a grade you received, please send me an email that explains your position (cc'ing the TA) and the original assignment within 7 days of receiving your grade. I will review the request and comments provided by the TA. I will either award you with additional points or outline my reasoning for maintaining the same score. I reserve the right to regrade the entire assignment if I think it is necessary to address the disputed issues, which can result in a lower overall grade than the TA originally assigned your submission.

GENERAL CLASS POLICIES

Email. Generally, I respond to emails within ~2 days. This is my personal policy and does not apply to TAs. I don't typically monitor email outside of normal working hours, so response times for emails sent on holidays and weekends will be slower. I check my email more regularly than Canvas messages, so please email me at ecampbell@ucsd.edu if you'd like a prompt response.

Deadline Extensions. I will evaluate requests for deadline extensions on a case-to-case basis. To request an extension, send me an email at least 2 days in advance of the deadline. Deadline extensions will not be granted after the original assignment deadline has passed, and at that point, the Late Assignment Policy applies.

Late Assignments. Late assignments will be accepted with penalty if submitted within 3 days of the deadline. I provide a short grace period for Canvas submissions, but beyond that, late submissions are penalized 5% each day they are late. Assignments submitted more than 3 days after the deadline will receive a 0. This is to ensure that students are not still completing assignments that others have received feedback/grades on, which could provide an unfair advantage. Late assignments due to emergencies, illness, or extenuating circumstances beyond your control will be evaluated on a case-by-case basis. It is expected that you contact me prior to the deadline, if possible, to discuss these extenuating circumstances and so we can develop a plan.

Academic Integrity (UC San Diego policy). Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind. The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at [here](#).

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities (UC San Diego policy). A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member. Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities by calling (858) 534-4382 or emailing osd@ucsd.edu. The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.

Health and Well-being. This class is not more important than your physical and psychological health and the well-being of you or your family. Many students deal with a range of challenging issues that can impact their learning, such as physical illness, housing or food insecurity, financial stress, strained relationships, loss of motivation, depression, anxiety, stress, or grief. If you are dealing with extenuating circumstances or ongoing challenges that impact your ability to attend class or complete assignments, please reach out to me as soon as possible so I can support you. We can develop a plan together that sets you up for success in this class. Below are several resources available to UC San Diego students:

UC San Diego Counseling and Psychological Services (UCSD CaPS)

(p) 858-534-3755 (available 24-7)

(w) <https://caps.ucsd.edu/>

UC San Diego Student Health Services

(p) 858-534-3300

(w) <https://studenthealth.ucsd.edu/>

UC San Diego Health Coaching

(w) <https://healthpromotion.ucsd.edu/services/health-coaching/index.html>

(e) hps@health.ucsd.edu

CLASS SCHEDULE – WINTER QUARTER 2026

To-Do Before Class	Agenda for Class
CLASS 1 (JAN 8). WHAT EVEN IS ORGANIZATIONAL STRATEGY ANYWAY?	
<u>Due before class:</u> Read the syllabus, please (including the generative AI tools policy)!	Part 1. Foundations of organizational strategy Part 2. Overview of course structure and assignments
CLASS 2 (JAN 15). THE CLICHÉ YOU CAN'T ESCAPE: WHY WHO YOU KNOW MATTERS	
<u>Due before class:</u> Submit Thought Question 1 response	Part 1. Using your social and professional network (“Organizational Behavior Simulation: Leveraging Networks” exercise)
<u>Read before class:</u> Networks exercise instructions & prep Roizen case (read p.1-11; skim p.13-17)	Part 2. Crafting your network and building social capital (“Heidi Roizen” HBS case) End of class: Complete Class 2 Exit Poll
VIRTUAL CLASS 3 (JAN 22). GROUP WORK AND DISCUSSION ON PROJECT MILESTONE 1	
<u>Due before class:</u> Submit Project Milestone 1 (select final project topic)	Part 1. Networks as a competitive advantage (“Le Montre: Information Networks and Markets” exercise)
<u>Read before class:</u> Le Montre exercise instructions & “Genesis of a high-tech hub” article (p.1-4)	Part 2. The lasting impact of organizational networks (The case of San Diego’s biotech hub) End of class: Complete Class 3 Exit Poll

To-Do Before Class

Agenda for Class

CLASS 4 (JAN 29). ORG CULTURE EATS STRATEGY FOR BREAKFAST

Due before class: Submit Thought Question 2 response

Read before class: Prep Microsoft case (read p.1-11; skim p.12-19)
(note: reading Amazon & Pixar materials before class is optional because these will be prepped in class)

Part 1. What type of org culture boosts innovation? (Amazon vs Pixar debate exercise)

Part 2. Changing a firm's culture ("Satya Nadella at Microsoft: Instilling a Growth Mindset" London Business School case)

End of class: Complete Class 4 Exit Poll

CLASS 5 (FEB 5). BEYOND THE (CONVOLUTED) ORG CHART

Due before class: Complete mid-quarter feedback survey (see Canvas for link)

Read before class: Org Design exercise instructions & prep Zappos case (read p.1-11; skim p.12-16)

Part 1. The consequences of organizational design choices ("Organizational Design Simulation: Evolving Structures" exercise)

Part 2. Exercise debrief & discussion about firm hierarchy ("Tony Hsieh at Zappos: Structure, Culture, and Radical Change" INSEAD case)

End of class: Complete Class 5 Exit Poll

VIRTUAL CLASS 6 (FEB 12). A MORAL IMPERATIVE: EQUITY AND INCLUSION IN FIRMS

Due before class: Submit Thought Question 3 response

Read before class: Prep BlackRock case (skim p.1-6; read p.7-21)

Part 1. What do we take for granted at work? ("Market for Privilege" exercise)

Part 2. Beyond increasing awareness: Firm initiatives to improve equity and inclusion ("BlackRock: Diversity as a Driver for Success" HBS case)

End of class: Complete Class 6 Exit Poll

To-Do Before Class

Agenda for Class

CLASS 7 (FEB 19). THIS IS WHY WE CAN'T HAVE NICE THINGS: CORRUPTION IN NETWORKS AND FIRMS

Due before class: Submit Project Milestone 2 (outline of final project memo)

Read before class: Prep VW case (read p.1-21) & read Excalibur mini-case materials (read p.1-6)

Part 1. It's not so simple: Ethical dilemmas in the context of workplace relationships ("Excalibur Construction or the Dilemma of the Young Go-Getter" HEC Montreal case)

Part 2. Catalysts for ethics violations in firms ("Volkswagen emissions scandal: How could it happen?" INSEAD case)

End of Class: Complete Class 7 Exit Poll

NO CLASS (FEB 26). PRESENTATION PREP – STORYLINE AND STORYTELLING

Due before date: Submit Thought Question 4 response

Read before date: Prep Toyota case (read p.1-11; skim p.12-16)

Part 1. Group check-ins on Final project workshop

By Feb 26: Complete Class 8 Exit Poll

CLASS 9 (MAR 5). WHAT YOU CAN DO ABOUT IT: FOSTERING CHANGE IN ORGANIZATIONS

Due before class: N/A

Read before class: "Networking and Influence Simulation" exercise instructions

Part 1. Change agents in action ("Networking and Influence Simulation" exercise)

Part 2. Influence and enacting change in organizations (Debrief exercise and discussion)

End of class: Complete Class 9 exit poll

To-Do Before Class

Agenda for Class

CLASS 10 (MAR 12). OUT IN THE REAL WORLD: FINAL PROJECT PRESENTATIONS

Due before class: Submit Project Milestone 3 (peer evaluations)

Read before class: N/A

Final project presentations

****Class time to complete course evals*

FINALS PERIOD: NO CLASS

- Open-book quiz will be made available on Canvas on March 12th at 6pm and responses will be due by March 19th at 11:59pm.
- Final group project written memo are due by March 19th at 11:59pm